Q+A

SACRED THOUGHTS

Pavan K. Varma's latest book—*Echoes of Eternity: A Journey through Indian Thought from the Rigveda to the Present*—is a collector's anthology, showcasing the breadth of Indian philosophical traditions

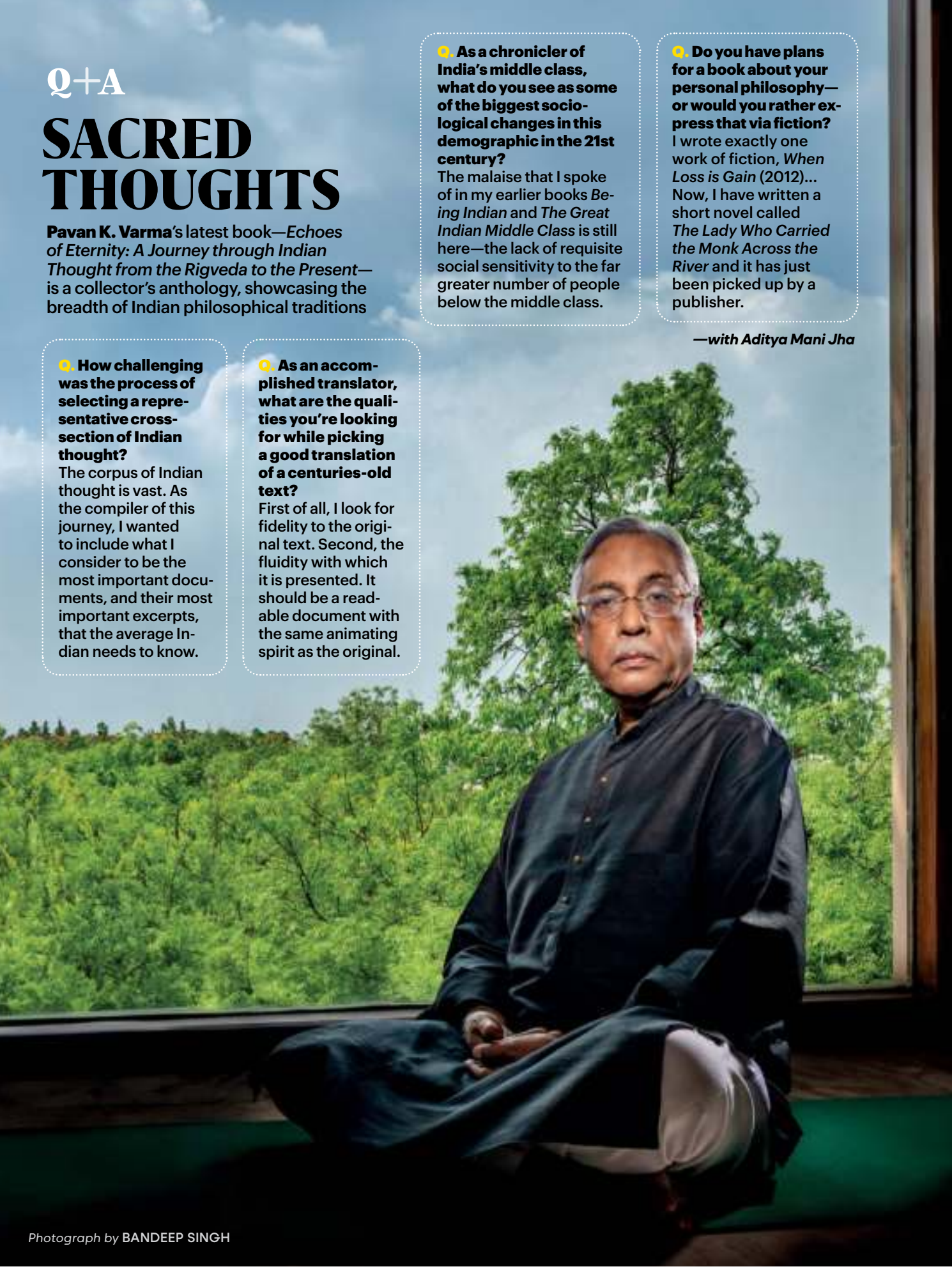
Q. How challenging was the process of selecting a representative cross-section of Indian thought?
The corpus of Indian thought is vast. As the compiler of this journey, I wanted to include what I consider to be the most important documents, and their most important excerpts, that the average Indian needs to know.

Q. As an accomplished translator, what are the qualities you're looking for while picking a good translation of a centuries-old text?
First of all, I look for fidelity to the original text. Second, the fluidity with which it is presented. It should be a readable document with the same animating spirit as the original.

Q. As a chronicler of India's middle class, what do you see as some of the biggest sociological changes in this demographic in the 21st century?
The malaise that I spoke of in my earlier books *Being Indian* and *The Great Indian Middle Class* is still here—the lack of requisite social sensitivity to the far greater number of people below the middle class.

Q. Do you have plans for a book about your personal philosophy—or would you rather express that via fiction?
I wrote exactly one work of fiction, *When Loss is Gain* (2012)... Now, I have written a short novel called *The Lady Who Carried the Monk Across the River* and it has just been picked up by a publisher.

—with Aditya Mani Jha



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